

Question 18 · Unit 1 · 8 Marks

State any two reasons why an HRD professional needs to understand organisational culture.

Introduction

Organisational culture is the deep shared way of life of the organisation — values, beliefs, unwritten rules, heroes, rituals. HRD climate is the current feeling about development. The HRD professional designs appraisal, training, feedback and change. If those designs ignore culture, they will be rejected or faked. For 8 marks, give two main reasons in depth and then supporting reasons.

Detailed points

- 1. First reason — so that HRD tools fit and are accepted.** A tool that works in one culture can fail in another. Public 360-degree feedback, outdoor adventure training, or very blunt confrontation workshops assume a culture that already values openness and equality. In a strongly hierarchical or family-owned culture, the same tool may be seen as insult, loss of face, or challenge to the owner. The professional who does not understand culture will import a fashion and create resistance. Understanding culture is therefore a design skill, not general knowledge.
- 2. Example for the first reason.** Suppose a professional copies a Western open-feedback form into a department where juniors never contradict seniors in public. People will write only safe praise. The data will be false, and later someone will be punished using that false data. A culture-aware professional would start with private coaching and boss-supported feedback, then slowly widen openness.
- 3. Second reason — to diagnose climate and pace change realistically.** Climate survey scores must be read against culture. ‘Low openness’ in a military-type organisation does not mean the same thing as in a start-up. Culture tells the professional what can change this year and what needs five years. Without this, HRD either does nothing (‘culture cannot change’) or shocks people with overnight new values. Both extremes fail. The professional needs culture knowledge to sequence change: what to preserve (e.g., respect, loyalty) and what to challenge (e.g., hiding mistakes).
- 4. Communication and legitimacy (supporting reason).** Messages about development must use the organisation’s language and respected persons. Culture tells who must sponsor HRD — the owner, the union, the professional CEO — for it to be believed. A technically perfect policy unsigned by the real power centre will not live.
- 5. Power, subcultures and fairness.** Factories, sales offices, IT groups and different regions may have subcultures. One national training design may fit none of them well. Understanding culture includes these pockets, which is also an equity issue.
- 6. Strategy needs a certain culture.** If strategy requires innovation, the professional must know whether the present culture punishes honest mistakes. The gap between present and desired culture becomes the HRD agenda (new behaviours to develop).
- 7. Ethical reason.** Imposing a culture through HRD tools without understanding people’s existing meaning of work can harm dignity. Respect for culture is also respect for people — which is HRD philosophy itself.
- 8. Exam shape.** Two reasons as long paragraphs: (1) fit/acceptability of interventions; (2) realistic diagnosis and paced change. Then 8–10 lines on communication, subcultures, strategy, ethics. Conclusion: culture-blind HRD is technically neat and socially blind.

Conclusion. *An HRD professional must understand culture, first, to design tools people will accept and use honestly, and second, to read climate and change the organisation at a pace that will last. Culture is the context of all HRD; ignoring it wastes money and trust.*